

Before we can put a Buy button on the website

The website is built and it describes the product well. What it cannot do yet is take an order and take money. This explains why, in plain language, and asks you the questions only you can answer.

Prepared for

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Development

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How to use this document

The first part explains the obstacles. The second part is a numbered list of questions, each with a hint telling you how to work out the answer. The last page lists documents to collect.

You do not need to answer everything at once. The questions marked **Blocking** are the ones that stop all progress until they are settled. The rest can follow.

THE SHORT VERSION

One sentence: the moment we add a Buy button, you become the shop.

Right now the marketplace you buy from is doing a lot of work quietly in the background — taking the money, printing the bill, arranging the courier, handling returns, and carrying the legal responsibility for all of it. A Buy button on your own website moves every one of those jobs onto you.

None of this is unusual and none of it is a reason to stop. It simply has to be decided rather than discovered later. There are three kinds of obstacle:

1. Things that need paperwork

To accept online payments you need a payment company to approve you, and they check who you are before they will move money on your behalf. This is the slowest item, so it should start first.

2. Things that need a decision from you

What price you charge, whether you keep stock, what you promise about delivery and returns. These cost nothing to decide but they cannot be guessed by me, because getting them wrong costs you money on every order.

3. One thing that needs honest thought

If a customer buys from your website and the parcel arrives from somewhere else with somebody else's bill inside showing a different price, that customer will notice. This is the biggest single risk in the whole plan and it is obstacle 05.

What is already done

The website, the product description, the size information and the photographs' layout are finished. The order form, the payment step and the order list are designed and ready to build. They are waiting only on the answers in this document — roughly a week of work once the answers and the payment account are in place.

Who is selling, and how the money moves

01 You become the legal seller

Today, when someone buys through the marketplace, the marketplace and the listed seller are legally responsible. If we take the order on our own website, you are the seller. That means the bill, the delivery promise, the refund, and any complaint all come to you by name.

Why it matters: a customer who is unhappy has no one else to go to. Everything has to be something you can actually deliver on.

02 Taking card and UPI payments needs an approved account

You cannot simply put a payment button on a website. A payment company such as Razorpay or Cashfree has to approve you first. They will ask for identity and bank documents, and they will open your website and check it.

They specifically look for four pages: a privacy notice, terms, a refund and cancellation policy, and a shipping and delivery policy — plus a working phone number and address. If those are missing, the application is rejected.

Why it matters: this is the slowest step, often one to three weeks. Nothing else about payments can be finished until it is approved, so it should be started before anything else.

03 Bills, and whether you need GST

If you are not registered for GST you can still sell, but what you give the customer is a receipt, not a tax invoice, and you cannot show GST as a separate line or print a GST number. If your sales grow past the threshold, registration stops being optional.

Why it matters: printing a tax number you do not hold is an offence, and some buyers will ask for a proper invoice. It is far easier to decide this now than to rewrite bills after fifty orders.

04 Refunds have to come out of your account

When a customer pays the marketplace and cancels, the marketplace refunds them. When a customer pays you and cancels, you refund them — and if you have already paid your supplier, your money is tied up until that side is resolved.

Why it matters: you need a small cushion of working capital. Refunds are not frequent, but they always arrive at an inconvenient time.

The parcel, the promises, and the paperwork on the page

05 What the customer finds inside the box

This is the most important item in this document. If we keep buying from the marketplace for each order and having it delivered straight to your customer, then the parcel arrives in the marketplace's packaging with the marketplace's bill inside — showing the price *you* paid, not the price the customer paid.

A customer who paid you ₹399 and finds a bill for ₹222 will feel cheated, whether or not that is fair. Expect refund demands and poor reviews, and those reviews are permanent.

Why it matters: there are only three honest ways out, and you need to pick one. Keep your own stock and pack it yourself; or ask the supplier to ship plain, without a bill; or say openly on the website that you source the product, and keep your price close enough that nobody minds.

06 The customer cannot return it to the marketplace

They have no order there, so they cannot start a return. Only you can, from your account, and only inside the window the marketplace gives you. If a customer messages you on day six of a seven-day window, you have one day to act.

Why it matters: whatever return period you publish must be shorter than your supplier's, or you will sometimes pay for the return out of your own pocket.

07 You do not control the courier

Somebody else picks the delivery company and sets the speed. You cannot promise a date you do not control, and a missed promise is what turns a mildly late delivery into a complaint.

Why it matters: the website should give an honest range, not a date. We need a realistic range from you.

08 Some details are legally required on the page

Selling a packaged product online in India means the listing has to show the name and address of the manufacturer or packer, what the item is, the quantity, the price including taxes, the country of origin, and a customer-care contact. Separately, an online shop must show a legal name, address, a contact, and someone named to handle complaints.

Why it matters: two of these — the manufacturer's address and your contact details — are information only you can get. They are on the questions list.

09 Customer details are your responsibility

The moment the site collects a name, phone number and address, that is personal information and the law expects you to say what you use it for, keep it only as long as needed, and delete it if asked. This is straightforward — it mostly means a clear privacy page and not selling anyone's details.

Why it matters: it also means we should not add tracking tools such as advertising pixels casually, because they bring extra obligations.

10 Photographs, and having no reviews yet

The supplier's photographs belong to them, so we cannot use them on your own shop. Every picture on the site is currently a marked placeholder waiting for real photographs. Separately, a brand-new shop has no reviews, and a low-priced item from an unknown shop leans heavily on reviews.

Why it matters: photographs are the single biggest visual improvement available, and they cost only your time. Reviews will come once real orders are delivered.

Your business and the money

Under each question is a hint explaining how to find the answer. Write directly on this page if it helps.

A. Who is the seller

1 Do you have a registered business, or will you sell as yourself? **Blocking**

How to answer: most people start as a sole proprietor, which simply means trading under your own PAN. You do not need a company. Check whether you already have a Udyam registration, a shop licence, or a current account in a business name — if you do, give the exact name as printed.

2 Do you have a GST number? **Blocking**

How to answer: yes or no is enough. If no, estimate roughly what you expect to sell in a year — if it is well under the threshold you can usually operate without one for now. Worth one short conversation with an accountant, because it also affects whether you can claim back tax on what you buy.

3 Which bank account should the money arrive in?

How to answer: the payment company pays into an account whose name matches the identity you register with. Confirm you have an account in that exact name, and that you can supply a cancelled cheque or a statement.

B. Price and payment

4 What price will you sell at on your own website? **Blocking**

How to answer: work upwards from cost. What you pay the supplier, plus delivery, plus roughly 2–3% that the payment company keeps, plus a small allowance for the occasional return, plus what you want to earn. Then sense-check it against question 8 — a large gap between your price and the price on the supplier's bill is the risk described in obstacle 05.

5 Is delivery free, or charged separately?

How to answer: either is fine, but it must be shown before the customer commits — a charge that appears at the last moment is both bad practice and against consumer guidelines. Including it in the price usually sells better.

6 Do you want cash on delivery as well as online payment?

How to answer: cash on delivery brings more orders, but on a low-priced item a single refused delivery can cost more than the profit on several successful ones. My suggestion is to start online-payment only and add cash on delivery later if you are losing sales without it.

How the product reaches the customer

C. Stock and packing

- 7 Will you keep stock at home, or order one each time a customer buys? **Blocking**

How to answer: think about how many you could store and afford to buy up front — even ten units is enough to start. Keeping stock solves the bill-in-the-box problem completely, makes delivery faster, and lets you check each item before it goes out. Ordering per customer ties up no money but creates every problem described in obstacle 05.

- 8 If you order per customer, are you comfortable with them seeing the supplier's bill? **Blocking**

How to answer: open one of the parcels you have received and look at exactly what is inside — the packaging, any printed bill, and the price on it. Then imagine a customer who paid you opening the same box. That is the honest test. If the answer is no, you need question 7 or question 9.

- 9 Can your supplier ship without a bill inside, or in plain packaging?

How to answer: just ask them directly. Many suppliers will do plain or gift packaging if you ask, especially for repeat business. Get the answer in writing, because it changes what we can safely promise on the website.

D. What we promise

- 10 How many days does delivery realistically take? **Blocking**

How to answer: look at your last few orders and count the days from placing to arrival. Give me a range, not a single number — for example “usually 4 to 7 days, sometimes 10 to remote areas”. An honest range that we meet is far better than a fast promise that we miss.

11 How many days will you accept returns for, and who pays the return postage?

How to answer: find out your supplier's window first, then publish something shorter so you have time to act. If theirs is seven days, offering five to your customer leaves you a safe margin. Also decide whether a customer who simply changed their mind pays the postage, or you do.

12 How many orders a day could you actually handle?

How to answer: think about a busy weekday. If ten orders arrived, could you place, pack, and reply to all of them? There is no wrong answer — I just need to know whether to build for a handful a day or for volume, because they are different systems.

Details that must appear on the site

E. Contact and product information

- 13 Which email address, phone number and postal address should be published? **Blocking**

How to answer: all three are required by law and checked by the payment company. The phone can be a mobile and the address can be where you actually operate from, including home. The only real requirement is that somebody reads and answers them. If you would rather not publish a personal number, a second SIM is a common solution.

- 14 Who manufactures or packs the product, and at what address? **Blocking**

How to answer: this is required on the listing by law. Look at the box the product came in, or the supplier's bill — it is usually printed on one of them. If not, ask the supplier for the manufacturer name and full address in writing.

- 15 Can the supplier give you a document confirming the plastic is food-safe?

How to answer: ask for a test report or certificate. Until we have one, the website says the supplier describes it as BPA-free rather than stating it as fact, which is the safe position. With a report we can say it plainly, and that is worth having.

- 16 Who replies to customer messages, and how quickly?

How to answer: name the person and the realistic time — “me, within a day” is a perfectly good answer. Whatever you say, the website will promise, so promise something you can keep on a bad week.

- 17 Can you photograph the product yourself?

How to answer: a phone camera near a window, with the product on a plain sheet of paper, is genuinely enough. About forty minutes gets every picture the site needs. The important ones are: the whole product, a close view of where the egg comes out, and one standing on a real fridge shelf so people can judge the size.

WHAT HAPPENS NEXT

The order things should happen in

Two of these can run at the same time, and one of them is slow, so it should start immediately.

Step	What	Who
1	Apply for the payment account. This is the long pole. It cannot finish until the four policy pages are live, so step 2 runs alongside it.	You, with me
2	Answer the blocking questions. Numbers 1, 2, 4, 7, 8, 10, 13 and 14. Everything else can follow later.	You
3	I write the four policy pages — privacy, terms, refunds, shipping — using your answers, and publish your contact details.	Me
4	You photograph the product. Independent of everything else, and the biggest visible improvement to the site.	You
5	I build the order form and the order list, so you can see and manage what comes in.	Me
6	Payment is connected once the account is approved, and we test it with a real order of our own before anyone else can buy.	Me

If you want to start selling sooner

There is a shortcut. We can put a form on the site that takes the order details but no money, tells the customer plainly that nothing has been charged, and lets you phone them to confirm and take payment directly. That needs no payment account and could be live in a few days. It converts less well than a real checkout, but it lets you start taking orders while the payment application is being processed.

Documents worth collecting now

- ☐ PAN card — yours, or the business's
- ☐ Bank account details, and a cancelled cheque or recent statement
- ☐ Proof of address for the business

☐ GST certificate, if you have one

☐ Any business registration you hold — Udyam, shop licence, or similar

☐ The manufacturer's name and address, from the box or the supplier

☐ A test report or food-safety certificate, if the supplier has one

☐ Your supplier's stated return window, in writing

This document explains commercial and practical obstacles from a developer's point of view. It is not legal or tax advice. The points about registration, tax and required disclosures are worth confirming with an accountant, which is usually a single short conversation.